

# “ SUCCESS WILL COME TO THE SIDE THAT HAS THE LAST MAN STANDING. ”

General Philippe Pétain, 1916

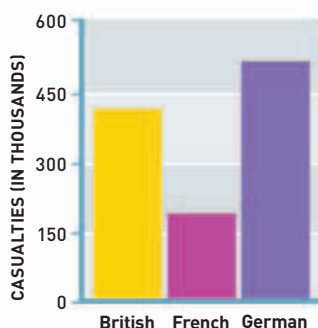


French soldiers arriving at Verdun in eastern France. The standard tour of duty at the front was eight days—all a man could be expected to stand.

launched a massive offensive at the **Somme** (see pp.344–45). Rather than destroy enemy defenses, the eight-day artillery bombardment had alerted the Germans to an imminent attack. British troops marched forward in lines, because the generals believed their conscripted troops were incapable of executing more intelligent tactics, and were mown down by German machine guns. Almost 20,000 men were killed, the **heaviest losses ever experienced by the British army** in a single day's fighting. Haig kept the men fighting for five

months, introducing tanks as soon as this new weapon was available, and allowing his subordinates to experiment with varied tactics including night attacks. But there was no breakthrough, and the only result was attrition—a gradual wearing down of the armies.

By the second half of 1916, the strain of two years of warfare had left countries with the option of either ratcheting up their war effort or seeking a path to peace. In August, Germany changed its leadership. General Paul von Hindenburg (1847–1934) and his



**Casualties of the Somme offensive**  
*The Somme was one of the bloodiest battles of the war. Between July 1 and November 18 over a million men were killed or wounded.*

Quartermaster-General Erich Ludendorff (1865–1937) were given supreme command of the German army and control of the entire German war effort. In order to wring every drop of productivity out of German industry, they created a state-directed economy that has been dubbed “**war socialism**.” By contrast, their Austrian allies were losing their will to fight. The death of Emperor Franz Josef I (1830–1916) in November marked the beginning of the **end of the Austrian Empire**. His successor, Charles I (1887–1922), was desperate for a way out of the war.

The collective madness of the battlefield provoked an **influential art movement** that gave itself the nonsense name **Dada**. Dadaists such as Hugo Ball and Hans Arp gathered at the Cabaret Voltaire in Zurich, in neutral Switzerland, and advocated a crazy antiart that satirized a world afflicted by mass slaughter. Their anarchic works rejected the social order that legitimized war.

A more rational spokesman for peace was **President Woodrow Wilson, elected for a second term** of office in November. As the man who had kept the US out of the European war, Wilson put himself forward as a peacemaker. He issued a “**peace note**” that called on combatant countries to



**Performing artists**  
*Leading Dada artist Hugo Ball performing at Cabaret Voltaire, which he founded in 1916. Dadaists protested against the war.*

state their war aims as a prelude to ceasefire negotiations. Germany's civilian government came up with its own “peace offer,” but the country's military leaders would not permit any of the concessions that might have made peace a practical possibility.

The **Russian Empire** was desperate for an end to the fighting, and its czarist regime was leaking popular support. In December, court conspirators assassinated Grigori **Rasputin** (1869–1916), an hirsute “holy man” whose hold over the czar's wife had become a public scandal. The assassination was widely welcomed, but it could not halt the czarist **government's slide toward collapse**.



**Going over the top**  
*British soldiers prepare to attack during the Battle of the Somme, leaving the relative shelter of the trench for exposed ground.*

